BOOK CLUB EXPRESS

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Family of Spies : A World War II Story of Nazi Espionage, Betrayal, and the Secret History Behind Pearl Harbor

by Christine Kuehn

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Discussion Questions

1. Imagine discovering a buried secret about your own family that is both horrific and essential to everyone's understanding of important historic events. How would you react? What would you do with that information? Would you rather know or not know?

2. Which piece of the story that Christine Kuehn uncovered surprised you the most?

3. There were so many moving pieces and moments that seemed like chance, such as Otto's not getting the job and being sent to Hawaii instead. Would history look different if they picked Otto instead of Heydrich for the original job in Germany and sent a different family to Hawaii? Would more Jews have survived the concentration camps? Would there even be concentration camps? And do you think these kinds of questions are valuable and worth discussing?

4. Did it surprise you that this was the family chosen by the Nazi party to liaise with the Japanese in Hawaii? What do you make of their lavish spending and early detection by the FBI? Do you think they believed they'd complete their mission? Do you think they knew they would be caught and detained if they did?

5. Discuss Friedel's motivations. How do you think Friedel's past relationships with men and loss of money by Otto contributed to her ease of becoming a spy? How do you think she dealt with the fact that Ruth was half Jewish, while her oldest son was a high-ranking Nazi?

6. What do you think drove Ruth's participation in the espionage? In particular, what do you make of her relationship with Joseph Goebbels, her activities courting military officers, and her letter to her brother from the concentration camp? What do you imagine were her motivations? Can you see any changes between the Ruth in the FBI files and the Ruth that Christine met later?

7. Why do you think Ruth and Friedel were not prosecuted as Otto was?

8. Keuhn's father, Eberhard, makes the decision to walk away from his family. Both Eberhard and Ruth decided to live the remainder of their lives in the United States by compartmentalizing their memories and past history. Do you think you could also walk away from your family, their actions, and their history? How do we rationalize our choices and decisions in life?

9. Think about the family's time in Hawaii. Can you imagine yourself living among neighbors for years knowing you will betray them? Does it call to mind stories you've heard in the news about spies being found in the U.S. living quietly among neighbors without raising suspicion? What do you think it takes to participate in such a mission?

10. The author writes about taking a break from researching this book for many years. Do you feel it should be up to each person to decide whether they come forward with important information that they uncover, or do we all have a responsibility to tell the truth, even if it is painful?

https://celadonbooks.com/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/9781250344465RGG.pdf

Author Biography

Christine Kuehn was cocooned in the sanctity of a quiet suburban life when a letter from a historian in 1994 pierced that bubble, sending her on a thirty-year quest to discover the truth behind a horrendous family secret kept hidden for half a century. Following a career in journalism, public relations, and nonprofits, Christine now lives in Maryland with her husband, close to their three grown children.

https://celadonbooks.com/authors/christine-kuehn/

Reviews

A Secret Defined Her Life. She Had No Idea.
In the thrilling “Family of Spies,” Christine Kuehn tells the story of learning the darkest of secrets.

by Sylvia Brownrigg

Like plants, family secrets come in different varieties. Common secrets include a long-past affair; the exotic variant might involve a second family. An invasive secret, on the other hand, is one that takes over and changes the meaning of the family itself. And discovering that your aunt and grandparents were Nazi spies definitely falls under this category.

Christine Kuehn had a close, loving relationship with her father, Eberhard — a fact with which the author begins her astonishing “Family of Spies.” The tall, imposing Eberhard still spoke with traces of a German accent, but described his family’s move to Hawaii in the 1930s only “in vague, whitewashed snippets.”

That Eberhard had been previously married and had two older sons was a fact that did not impinge much on young Christine’s happy life, though when her half brother once paid an unexpected visit, she remembers her father ushering the young man swiftly away, instructing him, “Don’t say anything about my family — they don’t know.”

It turned out that Christine and her mother knew little of Eberhard’s early life. His tales of having fought in World War II in the South Pacific were true; what they omitted was the profound gulf between his own wartime experiences and those of his parents, Otto and Friedel, and his half sister, Ruth.

These three Kuehns had remained loyal to the “Fatherland” — and had been dispatched by Joseph Goebbels to Hawaii in order to collect intelligence on the American naval fleet. Under the guise of running a steel company, Otto Kuehn steadily fed information to Japanese contacts to aid in an attack on Pearl Harbor. Another Kuehn son, Leopold, remained in Germany, moving from the position of Nazi storm trooper to that of a high-ranking official in Goebbels’s Ministry of Propaganda; he died at the very end of the war, defending Berlin.

Kuehn balances the story of her own dawning comprehension of her relatives’ Nazi activity with that of the Kuehn family’s time in Hawaii — a life of wealth, glamour and tropical island comfort that abruptly turned, after the bombing of Pearl Harbor, into a series of arrests, internment camps, trials and imprisonment. The family returned to Germany (without Eberhard) in 1945, in a prisoner-of-war swap.

Christine Kuehn first learned all this in 1994, when she received a letter from a filmmaker who said he was writing a script about World War II and was interested in her grandfather’s Nazi activities. She initially assumed he was mistaken, but after first stonewalling in response to her questions, her father finally broke down sobbing, and admitted what he knew. She would spend the ensuing decades poring over F.B.I. records, scholarly histories and family documents — and, eventually, meeting her German cousins.

“Family of Spies” is an amazing and gripping tale, full of suspenseful twists and cinematic details — though it must be said that Otto Kuehn’s espionage efforts were characterized by a fundamental sloppiness that might have been almost comical, had the consequences not been so dire. The family’s lifestyle was so lavish that it attracted the attention of local gossip columnists — and, ultimately, the feds. The F.B.I. agent Robert Shivers amassed a cache of damning evidence — mysterious funds, stashes of binoculars, a specially-built window from which to flash light signals to waiting Japanese ships — but while the United States was still in peacetime, his hands were tied.

The most colorful — and notorious — Kuehn spy was certainly Ruth, the product of Friedel’s first marriage to a Jewish architect. As a teenager, Ruth joined the girls’ wing of the Nazi youth group, campaigned for Hitler and had an affair with Goebbels. When the family moved to Hawaii, her ability to charm American servicemen became a valuable asset. Yet, after repatriating to Germany in 1945, Ruth ultimately returned to the United States, married and successfully buried her history, telling the author, in their one meeting, “You have a good life,” and “You don’t need to know about the family, the past or Pearl Harbor.”

As the story hurtles toward Dec. 7, 1941, the book acquires page-turning urgency. Kuehn’s research brings to vivid life the lead-up to the attack, and then its terrible devastation. And, ultimately, there is the catharsis of seeing Otto, Friedel and Ruth apprehended by F.B.I. agents.

Eberhard Kuehn, then 15, was repeatedly questioned until he finally convinced his interrogators of what he had insisted on from the start: A mere boy, he had played no part in his family’s espionage activities. That Eberhard enlisted when still underage to fight alongside fellow Americans seems unsurprising for a young man scarred by all he had witnessed — even if it meant he might fight the very enemy to whom his own parents and sister had remained loyal. And, of course, “that he would have to keep their secrets for life.

Sylvia Brownrigg is the author, most recently, of “The Whole Staggering Mystery: A Story of Fathers Lost and Found”

https://www.nytimes.com/2025/11/24/books/review/family-of-spies-christine-kuehn.html?eafs_enabled=false

Read-Alikes

The Traitors Circle: The True Story of a Secret Resistance Network in Nazi Germany – and the Spy Who Betrayed Them by Jonathan Freedland

In 1943 Berlin, a circle of elite anti-Nazi resisters - including countesses, diplomats and educators - unwittingly faces betrayal from within, as their decade-long acts of defiance lead to exposure, persecution and a reckoning with the cost of moral courage.

Children of Radium: A Buried Inheritance by Joe Dunthorne

In the tradition of When Time Stopped and The Hare with Amber Eyes, this subversive family memoir investigates the dark legacy of the author's great-grandfather, a talented German-Jewish chemist who wound up developing chemical weapons and gas mask filters for the Nazis.

Operation Sparrow: The Incredible True Story of the Spies Who Tricked Hitler and Won the War by Jason Bell

For fans of World War II history and spycraft, this is the extraordinary true story of three American soldiers who parachuted into Hungary, deep in Axis territory, and fed game-changing false D-Day intelligence to the Nazis who captured them.